

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

PRE-RETURN NETHERLANDS

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Name of practice	Datafication in Dutch Return Migration Infrastructure	
Dates	2020-2024	
Target group	Future Returnees	
Geographic Scope	Country	Netherlands
	Regions	Europe
	Sub Region	North Europe
Actor(s)	Dutch Repatriation and Departure Agency (DTenV)	
Return Stages	Pre-Return	
Challenge addressed	Governance, Cooperation and Coordination Monitoring and Evaluation Digital Infrastructure and Data Governance	
Principles referred (implicit or explicit)	Accountability	

SUMMARY

Within the wider chain of government agencies governing migration—under the responsibility of the Ministry of Security and Justice (known as the Vreemdelingenketen)—there is a specialized state departure agency involved in return processes (Dienst Terugkeer en Vertrek / DTenV). This agency collaborates directly and indirectly (through funding schemes) with partners such as the IOM, the Dutch Refugee Council, and other NGOs. A network of interconnected systems (SIGMA) enables data sharing between government agencies, including the Immigration Authorities (IND), the Central Agency for the Reception of Asylum Seekers (COA), the Immigration Police, the Identification and Human Trafficking unit (AVIM), and the Repatriation and Departure Agency (DTenV).

Each agency also operates its own tools: the Dutch Repatriation and Departure Agency (DTenV) relies mainly on ISTV (Return and Departure Information System), as all relevant information for DTenV case workers appears in ISTV (from the first AVIM hearing to EURODAC information).

Information of all kinds is linked through a migrant's unique V-number. This identifier is the key to unlocking a migrant's entire data trail, used not just by authorities but also by lawyers and advocacy groups. Meanwhile, systems like EUVIS (EU Visa System) and Frontex's RIAT (Reintegration Assistance Tool) extend this datafication beyond borders, capturing visa applicants' details -even those rejected-leaving lasting digital traces.

For migration officers, these tools are indispensable. They provide instant access to critical information, including health records, criminal history, and legal representation, across agencies like COA, KMar, and DJI.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

The Dutch migration system faces critical shortcomings in data sharing due to strict privacy regulations and role-based access barriers. Agencies like COA (asylum support) and DTenV (return agency) are legally restricted from sharing digital records—such as case manager reports or sensitive health data. This fragmentation

directs agencies to rely on informal workarounds, like verbal exchanges in meetings or hiring intermediaries (e.g., nurses) to access protected information, undermining transparency and accountability. These verbal exchanges are within legal practices but remain largely unknown to migrants.

A second major issue is the blurring of boundaries between care and control, particularly for NGOs. Programmes like the LVV (pilot programme on sheltering and return of undocumented migrants / 2020-2025) require NGOs to monitor migrants' return processes while providing support, turning them into de facto extensions of state surveillance. Systems like the Clientvolgsysteem (CVS) record and track migrants' details, but NGOs selectively share data with authorities, creating ethical dilemmas and practices of contestation. Migrants, meanwhile, are often unaware of how their data circulates, leaving them vulnerable to unintended surveillance and procedural unfairness.

KEY LESSONS

Standardisation vs local context. Harmonising migration data enables policymakers to identify trends and develop evidence-based, strategic interventions at scale. However, standardisation risks overlooking local realities and complexities, leading to policies that are less responsive to the actual needs and experiences of migrants on the ground.

Efficiency vs marginalisation. Digital systems, biometrics, and data infrastructures improve efficiency, monitoring, and enforcement of migration processes, fostering collaboration among stakeholders. Conversely, these systems can fragment data, reinforce top-down control, and marginalise migrants' voices, creating a surveillance-oriented approach that prioritises state and institutional agendas over individual rights and perspectives

Collaboration vs power imbalances. Expanding data-sharing platforms and collaborations support coordinated governance and legitimise policies through evidence-based decision-making. Nonetheless, these infrastructures may obscure power dynamics, reinforce hierarchies, and exclude migrants' lived realities, as data often reflects the priorities of states and organisations rather than those of migrants or local communities.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Standardise with flexibility and transparency. Establish consistent definitions and methodologies across datasets to improve data quality, comparability, and reliability. However, allow for flexibility to adapt to local contexts and ensure transparency by clearly documenting data sources, methodologies, and limitations. This balance builds trust, supports critical analysis, and prevents the reinforcement of top-down narratives.

Collaborate critically and equitably. Foster multi-actor collaboration among governments, NGOs, and migrants, while implementing oversight mechanisms to prevent data misuse and ensure equitable governance. Prioritise partnerships that empower migrants and local communities and critically assess power dynamics to avoid reinforcing hierarchies or excluding key stakeholders.

REFERENCES

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